



Jamaica AIDS Support For Life
Love. Action. Support

JAMAICA AIDS SUPPORT FOR LIFE LIVING SUPPORT ASSESSMENT REPORT



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April 2023

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List of Acronyms and Abbreviations

AIDS	Acquired Immunodeficiency Syndrome
CSEC	Caribbean Secondary Education Certificate
GPOP	General Population
HIV	Human Immunodeficiency Virus
IGG	Income Generating Grant
JASL	Jamaica AIDS Support For Life
MSM	Men who have sex with Men
PLHIV	People Living with HIV
PLWD	People Living with Disability
SW	Sex Worker
TG	Trans Gender
TRN	Taxpayer Registration Number

Introduction

JASL initiated focus group exercises across its three Chapters, St. James, St. Ann, and Kingston on March 23, 24 and 27, 2023 respectively. The focus groups comprised 5-10 randomly selected participants that represent PLHIV, MSM, and SW beneficiaries of the various kinds of living support - skills training, educational grant, back-to-school support for children; nutritional support and travel stipend; Income Generating Grants (IGG) and emergency shelters. Interviews were also conducted with beneficiaries in a single file based on their availability. This exercise was conducted by a team of technical staff comprising the Grants Manager, Medical Director, and the Psycho-social Support Officer that are not actively engaged in the day-to-day operation. The focus group was a means of assessing the outcome of the various kinds of assistance provided to improve health outcomes and overall well-being of JASL clients. The activity was also expected to improve documentation around the programme and close any gaps identified.

Living Support is delivered through the Treatment Care and Support programme that is built in JASL's strategic plan to improve the health outcomes of clients accessing services at its three treatment sites. The various forms of living support are recommended for clients based on their needs assessment and on the premise that there are adverse living conditions that may affect the ability of PLHIV to adhere to their medication and become virally suppressed or sustain their health status. The beneficiaries were engaged in discussions across the following areas:

Demographic Background

Each session commenced with the facilitators enquiring about the participants' background in terms of:

- Employment status
- Number of children or dependents
- Number of years being a client at JASL, and
- Skills or education attained.

Table 1: Demographic Characteristics of the Focus Group Participants

JASL Chapters	MSM	SW	TG	GPOP	PLWD	Total PLHIV
Kingston	4	2	0	2	1	8
St. Ann	3	3	0	4	0	10
St. James	1	1	0	3	0	5
Total	8	6	0	9	1	-

The table above represents the demographic characteristics of the focus group participants. Overall, 24 participants took part in the focus group exercise and individual interviews, of which 23 were PLHIV. The group also comprised 8 MSM, 6 SW, 9 GPOP and 1 PLWD.

A total of 14 of the 23 participants stated that they were gainfully employed in the fields of Customer Service, Security Officer, Gardening, Sales Rep, Room Attendant, Housekeeping, Food and Beverage, Taxi Operator, Shop Operator and Nursing Assistant. There were 9 participants that are currently unemployed mainly as a result of fragile health conditions, demands of child rearing or lack of job opportunities thereof. The duration that the participants expressed being a client of JASL ranges from 1 to 12 years. Among the participants were parents with dependents. In most cases, children were either accessing education at the primary or secondary level while there was occasional tertiary level.

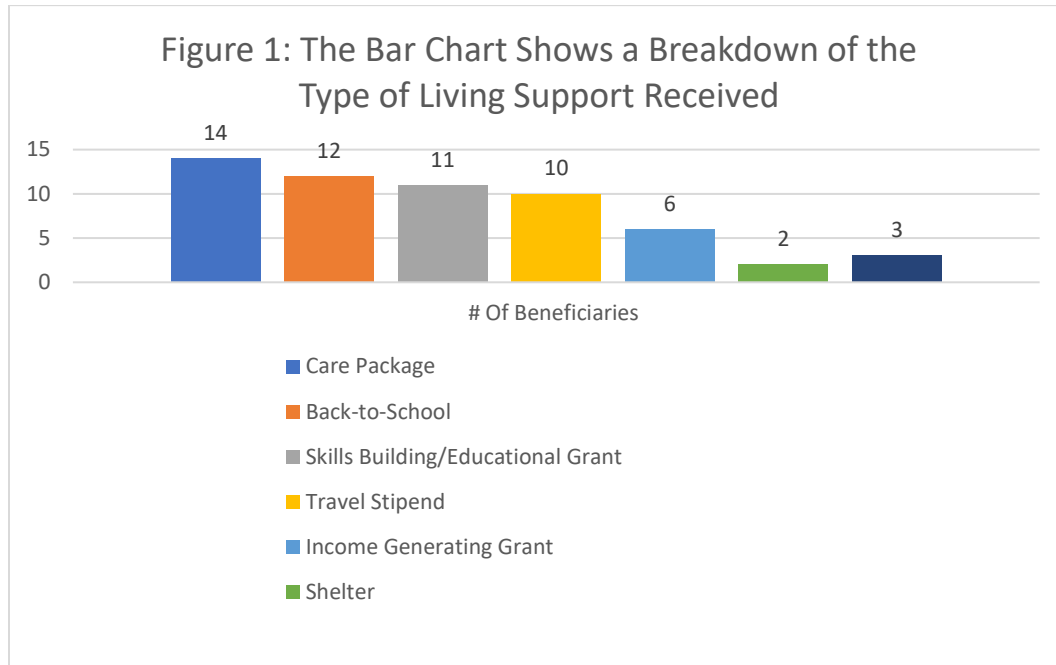
Table 2: Employment Status of the Focus Group Participants

JASL Chapters	Employment Status				Total
	Employed	Self- Employed	Part-Time	Unemployed	
Kingston	1	2	0	5	8
St. Ann	2	3	2	3	10
St. James	2	1	1	1	5
Total	5	6	3	9	23
	14				

The table above shows that of the total of 23 focus group participants, 5 were gainfully employed, 6 were self-employed and 3 were involved in part-time work. However, 9 of the participants were unemployed.

Type of Benefit Received and the Motivation for Requesting the Support

Nutritional Support, travel stipend, back-to-school assistance for children and educational/skills building grant emerged as the most common benefits received by the participants of the focus groups. A few participants were recipients of small grants to kickstart their businesses.



The bar chart above shows that care package (14), back-to-school support (12), skills building/educational grant (11) were among the top 3 categories of support received.

Some of the participants explained that their most predominant need at the time was financial support to register for CSEC exams to further their education through certification courses to elevate their employability. Other common circumstances that required support were costs associated with children in schools such as tuition and books. It was also highlighted that in some cases, the father was not present because of either death or inactive engagement providing for the child/children. This placed a burden on the mother to seek other possibilities to make ends meet and in most cases the IGG was a viable alternative to “try a thing”. Further to this, it was stated that the COVID-19 pandemic impacted their livelihood and made it difficult to provide for their families. This challenge generated greater need for nutritional support and assistance with back-to-school supplies for children. One parent expressed that because she was not able to provide

for her child to attend school consistently, she observed a regression in the child's performance in school. It was at this point that she reached out to JASL for the support she was not able to provide for her child at the time.

Stigma and Discrimination experienced in family setting and gender-based violence were also emerging contributory factors for persons seeking skills or business grants to become self-sufficient or high achievers to be recognized as a person not just living with HIV. The participants that received assistance with emergency shelter regard this benefit as very helpful. For some of the participants, it was as simple as not being able to pay their rent and, in some cases, faced with being evicted or living in unstable conditions with family.

Participants' Perception of Living Support

The participants spoke highly of the treatment and support received from JASL. One of the participants said, "if we are to sit around and tell you the depth of what the organization has done for us, anuh today the session ago done". They thanked the treatment team for always being there for them and responding to their needs, which is of tremendous benefit to them. For the most part, participants found the processing of their request as timely and sufficient to needs expressed at the time asked.

Impact of Living support on Overall Wellbeing

All participants in the focus group sessions, except for one, declared that their treatment has been going well and they have maintained an undetectable status. As for the anomaly, the individual expressed that for years she had maintained undetectable status and was operating a progressive cook shop. However, persons within her environment that learnt about her HIV status began to share it with other community members and caused her to be discriminated against. This caused her business to take a downturn which she eventually closed because people stopped buying from her cook shop. The situation affected her negatively and caused her to become depressed and stop taking her medication.

The vast majority explained that their health and treatment adherence was generally good before any major living support was received. However, the travel stipend was helpful to maintain and support the attendance of the clinic. One elderly participant mentioned that if it was not for

JASL and this kind of support he would not be able to keep up with his health. One participant stated that she benefitted from funding to support her certification programme as a security guard. She said that prior to this achievement, she was a market vendor where it was very difficult to stay in operation due to the constant run-in with Police Officers and other vendors. As a result, she wanted to just get out and seek something that was more enabling and sustainable. Another participant attested that because of the empowerment received from JASL, she felt more confident within herself and more valuable to society. Among the focus group were two other persons that benefitted from IGG. These participants have been operating small businesses for over 20 years which allow them to cover bills and maintain their families. A participant had received support by getting her Birth Certificate, TRN and Identification Card that she lost in a fire. As a result, it was very difficult for the individual to conduct any form of business until JASL intervened and assisted her with resolving the matter.

A participant shared that he was discriminated against due to his HIV status by his own mother who he was living with at the time. He mentioned that his mother had even gone to the extent of restricting his interaction with his younger siblings and this affected him severely. He said that he sought assistance to gain certification through the skills building grant. This he mentioned gave him the opportunity to uplift himself and become financially stable to the extent of renting his own apartment. He also mentioned that because he has been progressive, his mother has started to treat him a lot better and view him as one with ambition. It was shared by one participant that “in COVID di little food stretch far and wide. During COVID, I wasn’t working because at that time I used to depend solely on ships... when I get di food enuh man, a one-one slice a day and it works for the entire family- mother, sister, and children”.

Back-to-school support has also been helping the children with staying in school and performing well. As for others with children, it was expressed that their child exhibits great potential despite not being up to par in some of the subject areas. Some of the children that have received back-to-school support are attending prominent secondary schools in Jamaica and a few are pursuing studies at the tertiary level. There was also a participant that identified as a female sex worker. She mentioned that her “hustle” is the only way she earns, and the assistance received from JASL was very helpful to keep her daughter in school and retain good grades. At one point,

she received an educational grant, however, her “hustle” at the time was conflicting with classes and which led to a premature end to the course she was enrolled in at HEART.

Identified Gaps

A common factor identified among the support group was that recipients of income generating grants have struggled to sustain their businesses for the most part. Of the 6 individuals that identified with receiving IGG, only 3 have managed to maintain operation. Some of these ventures were unsuccessful because of lack of financial management skills, whereas persons tend to use money from the business to attend to personal matters without a plan to replenish or sustain the business. Additionally, it was realized that some of the beneficiaries did not have a structure and proper guidance to support the operation of the business. For example, one business failed because adequate repair was not rendered to the structure where a cook shop was being operated. In this case, a monitoring mechanism surrounding IGG specifically may help to provide the kind of support and coaching required to strengthen the operation of the businesses as this is an area needing attention.

Opportunities for skills building and educational grants provided to clients in need of this kind of support have helped them to harness their skills and make them become employable. While 9 of the 11 beneficiaries of skills building/educational grants have managed to successfully complete certification courses and transition into some form of employment, others have found it difficult to secure a job. On this basis, there is a need for more networking opportunities or collaboration with a set of entities that can assist individuals with certification courses to acquire work or practical experience.

Back-to-school support provided to children living with or affected by HIV has not only offset a lot of the financial burden off parents that find it difficult to send their children to school but have also helped the children to attain the highest level of education. Based on reports of children performing well in schools and some of these children having matriculated to universities, there is an expected spinoff on the reduction of poverty and intergenerational vulnerability to HIV/AIDs. Although this is one of the most common supports received by the focus group participants, requests for back-to-school support had far exceeded the actual support provided in year one of the Global Fund Grant. The provision of this support was further removed from year

two budget and could have implications on gains achieved over the years through this form of support.

Conclusion and Recommendations

Overall, the administration of living support has been consistent with supporting the biopsychosocial needs of the clients. The various forms of living support have helped the clients to maintain stability and treatment adherence. The clients have benefited mostly from nutritional support, back-to-school support, skills building/education and grant and travel stipend. This revelation corroborates with a recent study that was conducted on JASL's implementation of the COVID-19 Response which highlighted 56% of the participants surveyed having received support from JASL and over 70% expressed that the support received was very good. Based on the feedback from the focus groups discussions, the living support provided to clients helps with their stability and protects them from environmental threats that could disrupt treatment outcomes.

It was found that some of the beneficiaries have elevated their employment status through certification courses. Similarly, children that received back-to-school were able to attend school more regularly and perform better with their grades. Furthermore, there were a few recipients of IGG that have managed to sustain their businesses for years and have helped them to support their family and take care of bills. However, there are recipients of IGG that have failed to continue their business as a result of mismanagement.

Support groups are found to be a fundamental part of the care and support programme that helps the client to stay on course, whether it be with medication, mental health, entrepreneurship, or education. The clients being a part of a support group helps them to connect with others who are facing similar challenges such as family ostracization, stigma, financial challenges, treatment adherence or instability. As many of the focus group participants attested that support groups are like family to them and helped them to become better versions of themselves. This may suggest that in the implementation of living support, targeted support groups may help to advance positive outcomes in individuals accessing certain support. For example, an entrepreneurship support group for persons accessing IGG. This may provide new entrepreneurs with knowledge, lessons learnt and encouragement from the more seasoned entrepreneurs that are doing well with the continuity of their businesses. The support groups were also found to be crucial for providing an enabling space for individuals that were depressed by their financial situation or being ostracized by family

members and even to the point of attempting or contemplating suicide. On this basis, the support groups help the clients to balance their mental and biomedical health. The following may also help to strengthen the implementation of living support:

- Develop and enhance the monitoring mechanism of living support.
- Implement more targeted entrepreneurship training/ coaching for micro grant recipients to develop entrepreneurial skills.
- Broaden sensitization around stigma and discrimination in volatile communities.
- Implement capacity building training for implementers of living support to strengthen the programme outcomes.
- Broaden and sustain back-to-schools support for orphans and vulnerable children.
- Build networks with corporate entities to facilitate job opportunities for individuals that undergo skills training or certification programmes.

Appendix

Focus Group Questions

Introduction:

Thank you for taking the time out of your schedule to join our conversation about the support you have received through Jamaica AIDS Support For Life (JASL) treatments care and support programme. Most of you may be familiar with skills training, educational and back-to-school support, nutritional support, and travel stipend; income generating grants and support with short-term housing as part of the broad living support classification.

My name is Hezekiah Hall, Grants Manager, and with me is Dr. Jennifer Tomlinson, Medical Director and Christina Gordon, Psycho-social Support Officer.

You were invited because you benefitted from one or more of the above-mentioned interventions. The purpose of today's discussion is to hear from you how the support received has helped you to improve your overall wellbeing and towards the goal of becoming virally suppressed.

We are interested in hearing from each of you and expect that you will have differing points of view. Please feel free to share your point of view even if it differs from what others have said. We are also tape recording the session because we don't want to miss any of your comments.

Your participation in this exercise will help us at JASL to capture the impact of psycho-social support provided to clients, improve documentation around the programme as well as closing any gaps.

Let's begin by having each person in the room tell us their name and type of support received.

Questions:

- 1) What was your need or main motivation for the support at the time of request?
- 2) How did that gap prevent you from achieving optimum health outcomes?
- 3) Let's talk about your experience with the area of support provided to you. What was this like in terms:
 - The processing of applications.
 - Approval time
 - Challenges encountered during the application process
- 4) Did the support provided cater to the needs expressed?
 - In what way did the programme support your needs?
 - Was the support received adequate based on the need expressed at the time?
 - Was there any further expectation of JASL following approval of request?

- Was there any shortcoming?
- 5) Did the support help you to improve your overall well-being?
- What would you describe the effect on your overall wellbeing to be?
 - Where there any changes or improvements relating to:
 - i. job security
 - ii. education
 - iii. business venture
 - iv. self sufficient
 - v. treatment adherence
 - vi. Mental Health
- 6) What other areas of support can provide you with?
- 7) Please share your challenges and recommendations with regards to the support you received.